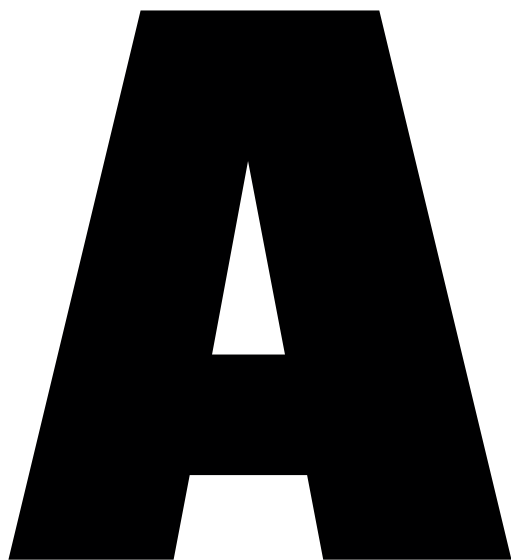




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ANY COMPANY THAT has made a significant turn in its business journey would have a serendipitous moment to thank. For India's biscuits market leader, the Bengaluru-headquartered, ₹14,000-crore (FY22 consolidated revenues) Britannia—a part of The Wadia Group—that moment came six years ago. Company chief Varun Berry was mulling the need to strengthen the non-biscuits portfolio, given how fast the country's tastes were changing in an era of retail shelves stacked with a bewildering array of lip-smacking snacks. Berry, who had been Britannia's boss for about two years at the time, recalled a gentleman that his erstwhile employer PepsiCo had partnered with in Mexico and Eastern Europe, a man with a formidable reputation in bakery snacks. "They [PepsiCo] had a partnership with him then, though I did not know him at all," says Berry.

Not sure what to expect, Berry dialled the man, Spyros Theodoropoulos, who was then in Greece. Theodoropoulos was the Founder and long-time Managing Director of Chipita, the Athens, Greece-headquartered baked snacks major that was eventually acquired by Mondelez International in January 2022. The call went through, went well, and the rest, as they say, is history. "He turned out to be very proactive and in two months, his team was in our Bengaluru office," recalls Berry. "They were very forthcoming and the ability to move fast was a delight."

But why Theodoropoulos? It was a tactical move by Berry, who was then trying to understand how Britannia could leverage the croissant in India. For the uninitiated, Chipita's flagship product is the hugely popular croissant 7DAYS. Given the subsequent happy experience, this incident taught Berry, now 61 and Britannia's Executive Vice Chairman & Managing Director, a valuable lesson—if something is not your core, it is a good idea to work with a partner.

The croissant is a European bakery snack. And so the easy option for Britannia was to import and sell. However, the Indian palate is different and a *desi* approach was more practical. "We struggled to fine-tune the taste. A one-year project went on for over two years," recalls Berry. It was initially test-marketed in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, but there was still some work to be done on the recipe front. It was in the beginning of 2022 that the team got it right, says Berry. There were many iterations—Indians like a milk chocolate flavour in the cream, preferred fluffy bread instead of the layered version used in Europe, or just the right kind of wheat, which initially came from Australia before Britannia finally got it going with a supplier in Delhi. When Britannia Treat Croissant hit the market last May, it was a resounding success and it suddenly opened up a world of opportunities. "On the same manufacturing line, we can now do a strudel. For the croissant, we will have another line in Kolkata, which is really the home of the product," says Berry.

This success (let's get to the numbers in a bit) has given Berry the confidence on Britannia becoming a total foods company. Biscuits, where it is the market leader

“OVER THE NEXT FIVE YEARS, WE WANT TO DOUBLE OUR TOTAL BUSINESS AND THE NON-BISCUITS PART SHOULD BRING IN HALF THE REVENUE”

VARUN BERRY EXECUTIVE VICE CHAIRMAN & MANAGING DIRECTOR, BRITANNIA INDUSTRIES